



(CLOCKWISE FROM EXTREME LEFT) SHIV SAINIKS SET FIRE TO A MUNI POSTER IN MORADABAD; GAURI AND SUHANA KHAN AT INOX, MUMBAI; SHAH RUKH, KAJOL AND KARAN JOHAR AT THE BERLIN FILM FESTIVAL

constantly questioned in New York, London and back home about what he had actually meant. The question asked was whether we should be friends with people who have killed our own. And the other more troubling question was on his identity as an Indian. "But it defines who I am. My father would always tell me your mother may have given you birth, but I gave you India." His father's freedom fighter's *tamrapatra* is lying in a trunk with his papers with relatives in Bangalore and he intends to reclaim it soon.

The controversy captured the national imagination like a daily reality drama, making minor celebrities of people such as Sena spokesperson Neelam Gorhe who emphatically said that support "does not only mean giving shelter to terrorists, it can also be given in terms of moral backing" and allowing commentators to treat Rahul Gandhi's Mumbai visit as a spectator sport. Even as Shah Rukh was constantly on Twitter, addressing his audience directly, sometimes apologising to fans for "disturbing sentiments", at other times saying how tired he was of "interpretations of this whole undesired and sad affair", the film industry remained largely silent, having often suffered in the past at the Shiv Sena's hands. Some spoke up though and enthusiastically, like Kabir Khan, whose *New York* sparked off 9/11 as the big new Bollywood movie idea. As he



puts it, "When an icon like Shah Rukh decides to take a principled stand on something, people rally around him which was proved last Friday when Mumbai stepped out in such huge numbers to watch the film despite the threats." Sociologist Dipankar Gupta goes a step further, calling the Sena power monsters and bullies, adding that it was high time someone spoke up against them.

The realms of real and reel have now unwittingly become blurred. Rizvan Khan's message appears to be Shah Rukh Khan's message. In the film, when Rizvan attacks the bigot in the mosque for misinterpreting Islam, it may well suggest his own questioning of the Sena's fundamentalist stand on what makes a